



Playing the Periphery

A thesis submitted for the degree of MA
Games Design by

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Double line spacing, with the exception of indented quotations or footnotes.

Longer quotations (40+ words or 4+ lines): separate, indented text blocks w/o quotation marks.

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Abstract

My topic of interest lies at the intersection of paratextual, corporeal, and sociocultural aspects of iconic game titles and their impact on the industry's history. Paratext consists of surrounding media not included in the game itself but strongly influencing how the experience is accessed, framed, and understood. Material comprises the physical means and contexts of play, in turn shaping the experience through sensory input, physical feedback, and presence. Society and culture permeate the above two aspects: while paratextuality is encoded in media and materiality is embedded in technology, the sociocultural layer is embodied by players themselves through their shared habits, beliefs, and informal systems. The co-operation of this trinity is flavoured by the aesthetics of the game playing experience in its entirety.

My project poses the following question:

KEYWORDS:

aesthetics,
authenticity,
experience,
immersion,
materiality,
metagaming,
nostalgia,
paraphernalia,
paratext,
preservation,
retrospective,
transmedia

In what ways can contemporary game design achieve holistic aesthetic experiences in the likeness of iconic, historically acclaimed game titles?

The research perspective is mostly aimed at context awareness and experiential revision, although, nostalgia remains a latent yet potent factor that bears investigation.

Retrospective settings are being highlighted because most well-known titles from the past represent history as written by the victors.¹ With this in mind, I believe that game design can notably benefit from closely examining the external circumstances which frame any media product's release.

The theoretical research will examine existing frameworks established in game and media fields of study, intending to touch on fields and concepts such as experiential aesthetics, affect theory, procedural rhetoric, immersion, metagaming, preservation, and various design approaches. The practical review will survey an assortment of games whose play experience is notably characterised by contextual circumstances. This investigation is meant to derive patterns from exemplary case studies that can suggest ways of implanting the external layers of play experience into a new piece of playable media. With historical awareness providing the background, some of the findings will be incorporated into designing a digital artifact complementing the written one, accompanied by fictional context in the shape of lore and paraphernalia.

Comprehensive analysis of multiple real world scenarios is to be followed by a selection of applicable² approaches, which in turn will inform the directions taken throughout the design and development process. Concurrently, any relevant observations should be recorded with the intent to feed back into the writing and, eventually, provide a strong basis for reflection. Exercising theory in practice is expected to direct the unfolding of the game's design. The goal that I aspire to achieve with this project is tracing a model of media creation that is elevated by its surrounding context, and also aligns with key values established in my personal game design philosophy (GD5609, 2025), then put the resulting framework into future practice.

¹Or, in a few amusingly infamous cases, the kitschy underdogs and dark horses that are often both cautionary tales and subjects of cult following. Evidently, if one struggles to attain immortality via glory, becoming an anecdote remains a viable alternative.

²A word which here means (Snicket, 1999) "feasible".

Chapter 1

Introduction

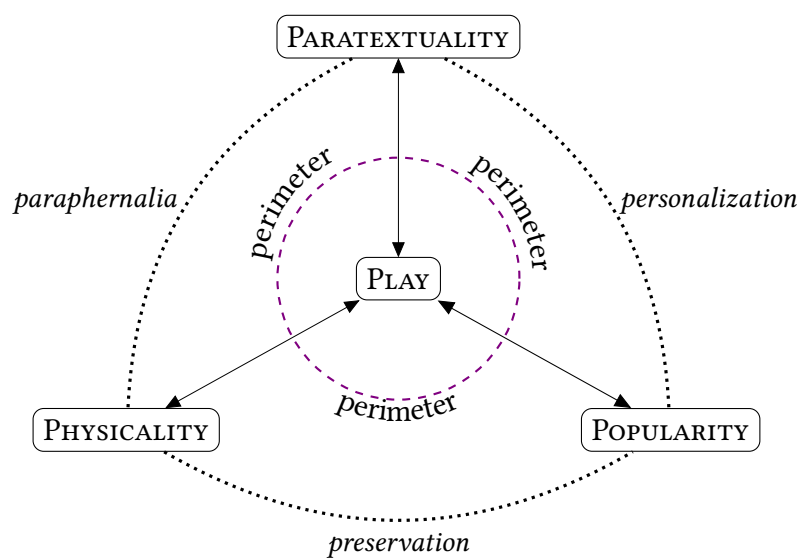


Figure 1.1: Peripheral aspects of play

Declaration of research topic and question, their field

relevance to game studies

Clarification of vocabulary: 'holistic'

Clarification of vocabulary: 'authenticity'

Clarification of vocabulary: 'experiential aesthetics'

Pitch of the practical part

Connection to the writing.

Overview of primary and secondary titles

Chapter 2

Literature Review

Definition of key terminology

contextualising the P-trinity through secondary sources

Friedrich Adolf Kittler versus Marshall McLuhan (McLuhan, 1964) on media theory

“Paratextuality in Game Studies: A Theoretical Review and Citation Analysis”, an article by Jan Švelch (2020)

Mechanisms: New Media and the Forensic Imagination, a book by M.G. Kirschenbaum (2012)

“Platform Studies: Frequently Questioned Answers”, a conference paper by Ian Bogost and Nick Montfort (2009)

“Social Realism in Gaming”, an article by Alexander Galloway (2004)

Metagaming: Playing, Competing, Spectating, Cheating, Trading, Making, and Breaking Videogames, a book by Stephanie Boluk and Patrick Lemieux (2017)

Cheating: Gaining Advantage in Videogames, a book by Mia Consalvo (2007)

Digital Playgrounds: The Hidden Politics of Children’s Online Play Spaces, Virtual Worlds, and Connected Games, a book by Sara Margaret Grimes (2021)

“The Cultural Field of Video Game Production in Australia”, an article by Brendan Keogh (2019)

Always Already New: Media, History, and the Data of Culture, a book by L. Gitelman (2008)

Confronting the Challenges of Participatory Culture: Media Education for the 21st Century, a book by Henry Jenkins (2009)

Play Between Worlds: Exploring Online Game Culture, a book by T.L. Taylor (2009)

2.1 Paratextuality, a.k.a. Supporting Context

The initial concept by Gérard Genette (1997) has been considerably expanded to better fit the field of game studies, and as a result has been entangled with adjacent terms from the original scholar's typology.¹ However, both approaches can be integrated into my own, owing to the generous overlap between the three types of external context.

When strictly categorising cases, Genette's definition regards "Elements that form a figurative threshold of a text and ground it in a socio-historical context. [...] must be created by the text's producers or their associates". These can be promotional materials, introductory sequences, menus, credits, making-ofs, contextual information about authors.

While preserving Genette's wording on which elements are included, Consalvo's interpretation assigns "...no limitations on authorship or cultural status" (2007). This is akin to *cultural epiphenomena* and allows consideration of more media like "criticism and journalism, user discussions, fan fiction and fan art, streaming, trans-media storytelling" (Švelch, 2020).

On these grounds, Genette's delineation is the more clear and straightforward directive for labelling purposes, while Consalvo's expansion on it draws a connection to cultural assimilation. Additionally, both have ties to materiality in their manifestation.

2.2 Physicality, a.k.a. Material Elements

proper lit review

The most tangible of the three aspects, this refers to all the material conditions in which the game is played. Exclusively, this covers authentic hardware and peripherals, physical data storage, haptic features, and environmental settings. In addition, paratextual supplements in physical format, e.g., paper, fall under the same category to form paraphernalia.

2.3 Popularity, a.k.a. Cultural Impact

proper lit review

Culture and society permeate the first two aspects via informal systems of shared habits, beliefs and conventions. The formation of social rituals by the demographic over time leads to emergent paratext, stemming from reception and circulation, and physical aspects are embodied in player presence and direct interaction with the hardware.

¹The five aspects of *transtextuality* are *inter-*, *meta-*, *hyper-*, *archi-*, and *para-*texts.

Chapter 3

Case Studies

Framing real-life settings in the context of paratextuality, physicality, and popularity

Media archaeology, theoretical framework application, ludic and paratextual analysis, comparative synthesis

A curated subset of primary sources listed in the lit review

along with:

“Reality has Always Been Augmented: Play and the Promises of Pokémon GO”, a book by Miguel Angel Sicart (2016)

Fan-based zines and archives, e.g., Your Sinclair, Commodore User, Compute!, Antic, etc.

The Internet Archive / The Wayback Machine (1996)

Chapter 4

Development

Chronicle of the RtD process

explain how interrogating a question via prototype design, theory informed practice and vice versa

Recognition/acknowledgement of any setbacks or limitations.

Primary sources with strong parallels to my direction Daniel Mullins Games, 2021

Guidance from reading:

✧ *Making deep games: Designing games with meaning and purpose*, a book by Doris C. Rusch (2017)

4.1 Prototype

Layout & UI:

screens correspond to hand placement: left hand collects water, right hand steers the truck
controls were "canonically" separate dials (and/or even meant for two players?)
here they are tied to a single mouse which is why each is confined to a single axis
loading bar tracks the mini-game's progress under the hood
maybe our goal can be to have the player ignore the launch button once it appears
tips will serve as ambiguous clues to what the main game is about; ordered so that juicier details come later on

Environment:

Trees at varied grown stages spawn over time
the bigger a tree is:
 the more likely it is to spawn small trees around itself
 the more flammable it is, but generates larger clouds
Raindrops fall at the same speed but appear faster from larger clouds
right now mouse buttons serve as pedals for the fire truck
already seems a bit tricky to multitask, I may automate movement
upgrades for the width of the water collector rewarded for successful fire management
that and/or auto-pilot for the car

"1-Bit Pack"; "Adore64"

asset hunt:
back-
ground,
frames,
UI (mouse
and bar),
steering



Figure 4.1: “Paper” prototype

tree growth stages

adult trees produce saplings

forest coverage -> cloud size

cloud size -> raindrops amount

correct car controls

auto-pilot for vehicle

upgradable bucket

auto-collecting bucket

score -> loading bar progress

4.2 Periphery

4.2.1 The Lost Game

High-level overview

Genre: RPG (narrative + systems-driven)

Player role (institutional, mid-hierarchy, specialised)

Core themes (responsibility, partial knowledge, delayed consequence)

Specialisation over general competence

Ambiguity through selective disclosure

Irreversibility of decisions

Systems that outlive the player

System Design (Implied, Not Implemented)

Skill trees: List studies/disciplines and what each excels and fails at

Progression?

Setting within the fictional layer (worldbuilding comes later)

C. Narrative & World Structure (Backstory as Architecture)

Historical scope larger than the game itself
Mention key institutions, past crises, and unresolved events

Identify known unknowns

Events everyone references but no one explains fully
Long-dead figures whose actions shape the present
Conflicting records or interpretations

Define branching allegiance paths (conceptual)

factions/institutions
Each has internal logic, incomplete worldview, and ethical trade-offs

4.2.2 Paraphernalia*Paratextuality + Physicality*

The material artefacts and design elements that mediate player engagement.
Talk about the manual with regards to gameplay

4.2.3 Preservation*Physicality + Popularity*

The state of survival, degradation, and community efforts to archive or interpret the game.

Describe the original control hardware and interface constraints

Dual dials, split controls, two-player operation as original hardware design
Ergonomic and technical friction encoded in surviving artefacts
Subsequent simplification or loss in later ports or preservation efforts

Map the technical state of preservation

Confirm what game software survives (e.g., only the loading mini-game executable)
Identify corrupted or missing files, UI assets, save formats
Detail physical media formats and archival status (cartridges, discs, hardware dependencies)

Write about the reasons and impact of loss

Technological transition between gaming generations as a cause
Hardware obsolescence and toolchain abandonment
How incomplete preservation shapes player experience and community memory

4.2.4 Personalisation*Paratextuality + Popularity*

The ways in which community interpretations and practices shape legacy.

Write a representative forum thread or community discussion excerpt that reveals factional or skill-based sub-communities forming around interpretations

Define cultural status and legacy

Position as cult classic, revered for atmosphere and design philosophy
Discuss how the game is remembered more than played
Explore how ambiguity fosters community creativity and personal meaning-making

4.3 Product**G. Internal design notes (fictional) on the Meta-Mini-Game**

Explain why it exists - frame it as preparatory or calibrational
It teaches multitasking limits and systemic tension
Ensure conceptual alignment

H. Dissertation Integration (not fictional)

- A reflective section linking the games
 - Mini-game as implemented theory
 - Lost game as designed absence
 - Ambiguity as holistic aesthetic strategy
- Explicitly justify incompleteness
 - As methodological choice
 - As historical simulation
 - As aesthetic design

Chapter 5

Synthesis

Revision of the artifact

Discussion on theory in practice

how the two informed, or clashed with, each other

Correlation with primary sources

Provisional answer to the research question.

Secondary sources that share concerns with the artifact

Chapter 6

Conclusion

Reflect critically on what has been achieved

Outline implications and further open-ended research directions to build upon.

Recommend reading/playing not mentioned in earlier chapters

Add final word count after conclusions and before references; not including acknowledgements, references, footnotes, appendices

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Appendix A

Paratexts

A.1 Manual

gameplay manual

hardware manual

A.2 Articles

A.2.1 Magazine preview

Magazine preview article

A.2.2 Webpage review

Webpage review article

A.3 Mesage board(s)

scaffold HTML page

fill thread with comments